Android App — Play Store Publishing Guide

Google Play Store — 1st Time Publishing Guide

Common Issues, Gotchas & Real-World Lessons

Document Purpose	Complete guide for publishing Android app on Google Play Store for the first time — requirements, policies, testing rules, common rejection reasons & real-world issues.
Applies To	New personal Google Play developer accounts created after November 13, 2023. React Native / Android developers publishing first app.

1. Account & Initial Setup Requirements

1.1 Google Play Developer Account

Before you can publish any app, you need a verified Google Play Console account. Here are the key requirements:

- One-time registration fee of $25 USD (non-refundable)
- Google Account (Gmail) required — use a dedicated account for your app business
- Identity verification required — Google may ask for government ID
- For new personal accounts created after November 13, 2023: physical Android device verification required via the Play Console mobile app
- Organization accounts: Stricter verification, but no 12-testers/14-days requirement

> 💡 **Pro Tip: Personal vs Organization Account**
> If you are publishing as a company/business, register as an Organization account. Organization accounts do NOT need to do the 12 testers for 14 days closed testing. This can save you 2+ weeks of delay on your first launch.

1.2 Developer Account Types Comparison

Feature	Personal Account (after Nov 2023)	Organization Account
Closed Testing Required	✅ YES — 12 testers, 14 days	❌ Not required
Physical Device Verification	✅ Required	❌ Not required
Identity Check	Basic Google ID	Company/business verification
Time to First Publish	~3–4 weeks minimum	~3–7 days
Best For	Solo indie developers	Company / startup apps

2. Closed Testing — 12 Testers for 14 Days

> ⚠️ **MOST COMMON MISTAKE — Read This First!**
> Many developers (including the author of this document) wasted 14 days by using the same few devices with multiple email accounts, or by having testers uninstall and reinstall the app. Both of these are WRONG. Read the rules below carefully before starting your 14-day countdown.

2.1 What is Closed Testing?

Closed Testing (also called the Alpha track) is a mandatory step for all new personal Google Play developer accounts created after November 13, 2023. You must run a closed test with real users before you are allowed to publish your app to production (public).

▸ **Official Google Requirements:**

- Minimum 12 testers must opt-in to your closed test
- They must remain opted-in continuously for at least 14 days
- The 14-day countdown starts only after your release is approved AND 12+ testers are opted in
- Testers must use real Android devices with genuine Google accounts
- Emulators, bots, and duplicate Gmail accounts do NOT count

2.2 The Opt-In Process (How It Actually Works)

This is critical to understand. Testers do not just download your app — they must formally 'opt in' via a special link:

1. Go to Play Console → Testing → Closed Testing → Create Email List
2. Add minimum 12 unique Gmail addresses to the list
3. Upload your AAB build and submit for review (takes 3–5 days)
4. Once approved, Play Console gives you a unique opt-in link
5. Share this opt-in link with your 12+ testers
6. Each tester must click the link ON their Android device and accept the invitation
7. Tester then downloads your app from Play Store (using the same Google account)
8. 14-day clock starts once all 12 testers are opted in
9. After 14 days, go to Dashboard → Apply for Production

2.3 Critical Rules — Do NOT Make These Mistakes

❌ MISTAKE #1 — Same device, multiple Gmail accounts
Using 3 Gmail accounts on 4 physical devices = only 4 unique opted-in testers, not 12. Google tracks unique users, not device+app install count. You had 12 tester emails but only 4 devices — so really only 4 real opt-ins were active. The 14 days was wasted because you didn't have 12 UNIQUE opted-in users.

❌ MISTAKE #2 — Uninstalling the app resets the test
(MYTH — this is FALSE) Uninstalling the app does NOT reset or remove a tester's opt-in status. Opt-in status is tied to the Google account and the opt-in link, not to the app installation. Testers do NOT need to keep the app installed for 14 days. They just need to remain opted-in (not click 'Opt Out' on the testing web page).

✅ CORRECT Way — 12 Unique Devices + 12 Unique Gmail Accounts
Each tester must be a different person with their own personal Gmail account on their own Android device. You need 12 real people, each using their own phone and their own Google account. They opt in once, and the 14-day timer runs. They don't need to open the app every day — they just must not opt out.

2.4 Finding 12 Testers — Practical Solutions

- Friends, family, colleagues — ask them to opt in with their personal Gmail on their Android phone

- Developer communities — exchange testing with other developers (they test your app, you test theirs)
- Testers Community app (testerscommunity.com) — free community of 40,000+ developers who exchange testing
- Paid testing services — platforms like PrimeTestLab offer verified testers starting at ~$10–15
- GitHub / Reddit / Discord developer communities — post in r/androiddev or relevant Discord servers

> 💡 **Pro Tip: Start Closed Testing Immediately**
> Start your closed test on Day 1 of development with even a basic/skeleton APK. You can push updates while the 14-day timer runs. This way, by the time your app is fully ready, the testing period is already complete. Don't wait for the app to be 100% finished to start testing!

3. Technical Requirements & Build Format

3.1 AAB Format — Mandatory

Google no longer accepts APK files for new app submissions to the Play Store. You MUST submit your app in AAB (Android App Bundle) format.

APK (Old — Not Accepted for New Apps)	AAB — Android App Bundle (Required)
• Single file containing all resources • Larger download size for users • Cannot be submitted as new app to Play Store • Still usable for internal/direct distribution	• Extension is .aab • Smaller install size for users • Google optimizes delivery per device • Required for all new Play Store submissions

3.2 API Level Requirements

- Target SDK: Must target the minimum required Android API level set by Google
- As of 2025: Apps must target Android 14 (API Level 34) or higher
- Google updates this requirement annually — check Play Console for current minimum
- Failing to meet target API level is a common automatic rejection reason

3.3 App Signing

- App must be signed with a release keystore (not debug keystore)
- Use Google Play App Signing (recommended) — Google manages your key

- Keep a backup of your keystore file — losing it means you can never update your app
- React Native: Use `./gradlew bundleRelease` with your keystore config in `build.gradle`

4. Store Listing Requirements

4.1 Required Assets

Asset	Specifications	Required?
App Icon	512 x 512 px, PNG, max 1MB	☑ Required
Feature Graphic	1024 x 500 px, JPG or PNG	☑ Required
Screenshots (Phone)	Min 2, max 8. Min 320px on short side	☑ Required
Short Description	Max 80 characters	☑ Required
Full Description	Max 4000 characters	☑ Required
App Title	Max 30 characters	☑ Required
Privacy Policy URL	Hosted URL with valid policy text	☑ Required
Content Rating	Fill questionnaire in Play Console	☑ Required
Tablet Screenshots	If app supports tablets	Optional
Promo Video	YouTube URL (unlisted or public)	Optional

4.2 Privacy Policy — Non-Negotiable

Apps without a valid, working privacy policy URL will be rejected — even if your app does not collect sensitive data. This is one of the top rejection reasons.

- Must be hosted on a live URL (not localhost, not a Google Doc that requires sign-in)
- Must clearly describe what data your app collects, why, and how it's used
- Must mention Firebase if you're using it (Firebase collects analytics/crash data by default)
- Must comply with GDPR (European users) and CCPA (California users)
- Free options: GitHub Pages, Notion public page, WordPress, or privacy policy generators

> 💡 **Free Privacy Policy Tools**
> Use free generators like privacypolicygenerator.info, app-privacy-policy-generator.firebaseapp.com, or termsfeed.com. For React Native + Firebase apps,

make sure to mention Firebase Analytics, Firebase Crashlytics, and any other Firebase services you use.

5. Common Rejection Reasons

#	Rejection Reason	How to Avoid
1	Closed testing not completed (12 testers / 14 days)	Get 12 real users on 12 unique devices to opt-in. Start early.
2	Broken or missing Privacy Policy URL	Host a valid privacy policy on a live URL before submitting.
3	App crashes on launch or has critical bugs	Test thoroughly on multiple devices and Android versions. Check Crashlytics.
4	Missing or incorrect content rating	Complete the IARC questionnaire honestly in Play Console.
5	Misleading app description or screenshots	Description must accurately reflect what the app actually does.
6	Requesting unnecessary permissions	Only declare permissions your app genuinely needs. Remove unused ones.
7	Target API level too low	Target API 34+ (Android 14). Check Google's current minimum annually.
8	App submitted as APK instead of AAB	Build .aab with `./gradlew bundleRelease`. Don't upload APK.
9	No login credentials provided for review team	If app requires login, provide demo credentials in 'Notes to reviewers'.
10	Thin content / placeholder app	App must have real, functional content. No dummy/blank screens.
11	Copyright/trademark violation	Don't use brand names, logos, or code from other apps without permission.
12	In-app purchases not using Google Play Billing	All digital purchases must go through Google Play Billing API.

6. Android vs iOS — Publishing Timeline

One of the most common frustrations for developers is that iOS/TestFlight is significantly faster for first-time publishing compared to Android/Play Store. Here's a comparison:

Step	🍎 iOS (TestFlight / App Store)	🤖 Android (Play Store)
Developer Account Fee	$99/year	$25 one-time
Beta Testing Tool	TestFlight	Closed Testing (Play Console)
Minimum Testers Required	No minimum (internal: up to 100)	12 unique testers (personal accounts)
Mandatory Testing Period	No mandatory waiting period	14 continuous days
First Build Review Time	1–2 days for TestFlight approval	3–5 days for closed test build
Production Review Time	1–3 days typically	3–7 days after applying
Total Time to First Live	~2–4 days (fast!)	~3–4 weeks minimum (slow!)
Main Gotcha	Strict content/design guidelines	12 testers on 12 unique devices mandatory

7. React Native — Pre-Submission Checklist

7.1 Build Configuration

- Update versionCode and versionName in `android/app/build.gradle`
- Target API Level 34+ set in `build.gradle` (targetSdkVersion 34)
- Release build variant configured with correct keystore signing
- ProGuard/R8 rules set if using code minification
- Run: `cd android && ./gradlew bundleRelease` to generate .aab file

7.2 Permissions Audit

- Review `AndroidManifest.xml` — remove all permissions you don't use
- INTERNET: Required if app makes any network calls
- CAMERA, MICROPHONE, LOCATION: Only if your app genuinely needs them
- READ/WRITE_EXTERNAL_STORAGE: Deprecated in Android 13+, use MediaStore API instead
- POST_NOTIFICATIONS: Required for push notifications on Android 13+

7.3 Firebase Checklist (if using Firebase)

- `google-services.json` placed in `android/app/` folder
- Firebase Analytics: Mentioned in Privacy Policy

- Firebase Crashlytics: Mentioned in Privacy Policy
- Firebase Auth: If using, mention data collection in Privacy Policy
- Remove debug/test Firebase configurations before production build

7.4 Testing Before Submission

- Test on physical Android devices (not just emulator)
- Test on at least Android 10, 12, and 14 if possible
- Verify no crash on cold start
- Test with slow network / no network conditions
- Test back button behavior and navigation flow
- Verify all links in the app work (no hardcoded localhost URLs)

8. Step-by-Step: First Time Publishing Process

Follow this exact sequence for a smooth first-time launch on Google Play Store:

Step	Phase	Action Required
1	Account Setup	Create Google Play Developer account, pay $25, verify identity, install Play Console app on your Android device.
2	App Setup	Create new app in Play Console, set app name, default language, app/game category.
3	Privacy Policy	Create and host your privacy policy on a live URL. Add URL in Play Console under App Content.
4	Store Listing	Upload app icon (512x512), feature graphic, screenshots, fill short & full description.
5	Content Rating	Complete the IARC questionnaire in Play Console. Be honest — choose ratings that match your actual app.
6	Build Your AAB	Run `./gradlew bundleRelease` in your Android project. Output is at `android/app/build/outputs/bundle/release/app-release.aab`
7	Closed Test Upload	In Play Console → Closed Testing → Create track → Upload your .aab file → Submit for review.
8	Wait for Build Approval	Google reviews your closed test build. Takes 3–5 business days. You'll get an email when approved.
9	Get Opt-in Link	After approval, get the unique opt-in link from Play Console and share with your 12+ testers.
10	Testers Opt In	Each tester clicks the link on their own Android device, signs in with their Gmail, downloads app. 14-day clock starts.

Step	Phase	Action Required
11	Gather Feedback	While waiting, collect feedback from testers, fix bugs, push new builds to the same closed test track.
12	Apply for Production	After 14 days with 12+ testers, go to Dashboard → Apply for Production → Answer questionnaire.
13	Production Review	Google reviews your application for production access. Takes ~7 days. You'll get an email decision.
14	Upload Production Build	After production access is granted, upload your final .aab build to the Production track.
15	Go Live!	Submit for production review. Usually approved within 24–48 hours. Your app is now live on Play Store! 🎉

9. Real-World Issues & Lessons Learned

9.1 The 14-Day Tester Trap (Our Story)

> **What Happened:** We had 12 tester email accounts but only 4 physical Android devices. We installed and tested the app using 3 different Gmail accounts per device. After 14 days, our production access request was REJECTED.
>
> **Why It Failed:** Google requires 12 UNIQUE opted-in testers, meaning 12 different Google accounts using 12 different Android devices. Sharing devices between accounts does not count as 12 separate testers.
>
> **What We Should Have Done:** Ask 12 different people (friends, family, colleagues) to each use their own Android phone with their own personal Gmail account to opt-in via the tester link. 14 days of opt-in status = done correctly. No uninstalling required.

9.2 Other Common Real-World Issues

▸ **Issue: App Review Takes Longer Than Expected**
First-time app reviews often take longer than repeat submissions. Budget 7–14 days for the full process. Don't plan a hard launch date until you have production access.

▸ Issue: Build Approved but Testers Can't Find App

Testers cannot search for your app — they MUST use the opt-in link you share. The app only appears to users who have opted in via your specific testing link.

▸ Issue: Tester Count Drops Below 12

If testers opt out and your count drops below 12, the 14-day period may reset or stall. Always recruit 15–20 testers to account for dropouts. Monitor the count in Play Console daily.

▸ Issue: Privacy Policy URL Returns 404

Make sure your privacy policy URL is live and publicly accessible BEFORE submitting. Test it in an incognito/private browser window. Google's reviewers will check the link.

▸ Issue: App Works on Emulator but Crashes on Real Device

Always test on a real physical Android device before submitting. Emulators behave differently, especially with camera, location, and hardware-specific features.

▸ Issue: Wrong API Level Targeted

Google updates its minimum target API level every year, usually requiring the latest Android version. Check the current requirement in Play Console before every release.

▸ Issue: Release Notes Missing or Wrong Language

Release notes (What's New) must be provided in the language of your app's primary listing. If you target multiple countries, consider providing localized release notes.

10. Pre-Submission Quick Checklist

✅ Technical Checklist

- AAB format build (.aab not .apk)
- Target API Level 34+ set
- Release keystore signing configured
- versionCode and versionName updated
- No debug/test code or keys in production
- All required permissions declared
- Unused permissions removed from Manifest
- App tested on real device — no crashes
- Network calls work on live API endpoints
- Firebase google-services.json is production config

✅ Store Listing Checklist

- App icon 512x512 PNG uploaded
- Feature graphic 1024x500 uploaded
- Minimum 2 screenshots uploaded
- App title (max 30 chars) set
- Short description (max 80 chars) written
- Full description (max 4000 chars) written
- Privacy Policy URL live and accessible
- Content rating questionnaire completed
- App category correctly set
- If login required: demo credentials added in Review Notes

🚀 **Final Reminder Before Submitting**

Start your closed test ASAP with a working build. Get 12+ real people (12 unique Gmail accounts on 12 unique Android phones) to opt in via your tester link. Let the 14-day timer run while you continue development. After 14 days, apply for production access. Then submit your final production build. Total time budget: 3–4 weeks for first-time Android launch.